

The Art of Listening

Chapter One

There is a particular kind of quiet that settles over a house in the early morning, before the first kettle has been filled and before the street outside has remembered its own noise. Eleanor had always loved this hour. She would sit by the window with her hands wrapped around a cup that was more warmth than tea, and she would listen.

Listening, she had decided long ago, was not the same as hearing. Hearing was what happened to you; listening was what you chose to do with it. The difference mattered on mornings like this one, when the world offered so little and asked for so much attention in return.

The letter had arrived the previous afternoon. It sat now on the table beside her, unopened, its envelope the pale blue of a January sky. She knew the handwriting. She had known it for thirty-one years, ever since a rain-soaked evening in 1993 when a stranger had held a door for her and then, inexplicably, apologised for the weather.

"You'll open it eventually," her daughter had said on the telephone. "You always do."

Eleanor had not answered. Instead she had asked about the children, about the dog with the bad hip, about whether the roof had finally been mended. These were the questions that kept a conversation moving in the right direction, away from envelopes and toward the ordinary comfort of other people's lives.

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